

Water bear

There are water bears everywhere. These micro-animals live all over the world, from the tops of mountains to the depths of the oceans. All they need is a little water. Water bears are around 0.5 mm (0.02 in) long, and use their hook-like claws to scramble over soft moss. They are also known as tardigrades, or moss piglets.

Water bears are the toughest animals of all. They can be frozen, boiled, have X-rays fired at them, or be squashed under massive pressure, and they will survive. If it gets too dry, a water bear shrivels up into a small package called a tun. When it gets wet again, the water bear swells up and walks off as if nothing happened, even years later!



In 2007, water bears were sent into space.

*They are the only animals ever to
have survived outside a spacecraft.*